

There is no genuine copula in Japanese — a reanalysis of 'da' as Postposition plus Existential Verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *dearu* and its contracted form *da*. Traditionally, *dearu* has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the separability between *de* and *aru* and the inseparability between NPs and *de* show that this interpretation is inadequate. In sentences such as *kare=wa gakusei dearu* 'he is a student', the noun phrase *gakusei* plus *de* behaves as a single constituent, while *de* and *aru* are separable. This suggests that *gakusei de* forms a postpositional phrase (PP) and that *dearu* should be reanalysed as the postposition *de* plus the existential verb *aru*.

Under this analysis, *kare=wa gakusei dearu* is syntactically an existential sentence consisting of the core clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual place "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The apparent obligatoriness of *gakusei=de* is informational and pragmatic rather than syntactic, since *gakusei=de* functions as the focus of the sentence. The paper also accounts for the negation pattern *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* instead of *kare=wa gakusei=de nai*, showing that the negator applies to the adjunct domain *gakusei=de* rather than to the existence of *kare* itself.

This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *dearu* constructions.

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1. Introduction — Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and inseparability between NPs and *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu*, as in *kare=wa gakusei=da* / *gakusei dearu* 'he is a student' ("=" indicates enclisis), have traditionally been treated as copulas equivalent to *to be* in English. However, this analysis faces a major limitation: it cannot account for **the high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***.

For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus particle — the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — *mo* 'also', the sentence cannot take the form **kare=wa gakusei=mo dearu* "he is also a student" but must be *kare=wa gakusei de=mo aru*, where *mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*. Furthermore, in *kare=wa gakusei deari*, *kanozyo=wa syakaizin da* "he is a student, and she is a professional", the first *deari* may reduce to *de* alone as in *kare=wa gakusei de*, *kanozyo=wa syakaizin da*. These facts show that ***de* and *aru* are separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* always remain contiguous** as *gakusei de*.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* constitutes a single inseparable constituent. This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =*de***. Therefore, in what follows, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*.

2. NP + =*de* as an adjunct PP

In Japanese, PPs of the form "NP + =*de*" function exclusively as adjuncts. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* consists syntactically of a **mandatory structure *kare=wa aru*** and an **adjunct structure *gakusei=de***.

In *kare=wa aru*, *aru* functions as a one-argument verb. When the verb *aru* functions as such, it means 'to exist' — though rather literary — and the sentence *kare=wa aru* can thus be interpreted as 'he exists'. As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although postpositional phrases headed by =*de* can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is therefore **locative** — not a physical but a **conceptual location**.

Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual place "student"'. The entire structure

kare=wa gakusei=de aru is thus, syntactically, composed of **the mandatory clause** [*kare wa aru*] 'he exists' and **the adjunct** [*gakusei=de*] 'in the conceptual place "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and the location of his existence is the conceptual one of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'.

3. The difference between *kare wa gakusei =DE aru* and *sore wa gakkō =NI aru*

In contrast to the construction *kare wa gakusei=de aru*, hypothesised as **existential** in Section 2, in genuine **locative** constructions such as *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school' and *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru* 'it is in the school', **the locative argument is obligatory and always marked by the postposition =ni, rather than =de**. This formal difference further supports the above analysis. The verb *aru*, when used as a locative verb, is a two-argument predicate with the argument structure [location, theme], the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =ni], as in *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* is used instead, with the PP [NP + =ni] unchanged, as in *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school', whereas **kare=wa gakkō=de iru*, which employs the PP [NP + =de], is not semantically interpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* should be regarded syntactically — though not pragmatically or informationally, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a structurally self-contained existential sentence, *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', with the adjunct *gakusei=de*, which specifies the domain of existence.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the mandatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual place "student"', serves as a **presentational sentence** in which **the focus is placed on *gakusei=de***.

Therefore, the non-deletability of *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP A <i>ar-</i>] + [AdjunctP B= <i>de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	'A exists, and it is in the domain B'	Existence + its domain restriction
Pragmatics	Focus on B= <i>de</i>	Pragmatic obligatoriness of B= <i>de</i> due to focus

5. Old Japanese forms

In Old Japanese, the modern *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* would correspond to *kare gakusei nari*, derived from *kare gakusei=ni ari*. Before the emergence of *=nite*, the postposition *=ni* could mark both arguments and adjuncts. Thus, *kare gakusei=ni ari* can be analysed as consisting of the core clause *kare ari* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=ni* 'in the conceptual place denoted by *gakusei*', which is consistent with the present hypothesis.

The subsequent development *kare gakusei=nari* → *kare gakusei=nite ari* → *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* reflects the diachronic split between *=ni*, used for arguments, and *=nite*, used for adjuncts. This may represent a shift from a linguistic stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively — a possibility that requires further historical investigation.

6. Scope of negation

Negation in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* 'he exists, and it is as a student' normally appears as *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* 'he exists, but not as a student' rather than *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* 'he does not exist as a student'. This is because the clause *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* does **not negate the existence of *kare***, but rather **negates *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**, since, in Japanese, *=wa* thus can mark the scope of negation, as in *gakusei=de=wa*.

If *dearu* were a single copular unit, partial negation with *=wa* would necessarily take the form **kare=wa gakusei=wa denai*. The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *de* and *aru* and the adjunctive nature of *gakusei=de*.

7. The contracted form **=da**

In spoken language, the contracted form **=da** is often used instead of **=de aru**, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=da* 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **modern contracted form =da** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex =de aru**. The historical change from **=de aru** to **=da**, possibly via **=dea**, involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but only a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de ele* → *dele* 'of/from him'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for **=de** and *aru* to form a single lexical item. The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: **=de** functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and *aru* as the existential verb itself. Therefore, **=da** should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction **=de aru** (more theoretically, **=de ar-0**, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix specified as [–past]).

8. Conclusion — *dearu* not as a copula but as the postposition **=de** followed by the existential verb *aru*

To summarise, the syntactic structure of *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' consists of a **mandatory existential clause *A=wa aru* 'A exists'** and an **adjunctive phrase *B=de* 'in the conceptual place denoted by B' or 'as B'**. It should therefore be syntactically represented as ***A=wa B=de aru***. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, composed of the existential verb *aru* and the postpositional phrase *B=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of *A* is realised. The more colloquial form **=da** is a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal **=de aru**.

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